

# Hadith Collection and Science

PART I & II

An introduction to the conditions of authenticity, categories of Hadith, and the scholarly sciences developed to preserve and evaluate prophetic narrations.



# Structure of a Hadith

A Hadith is composed of three main components, each crucial for its understanding and authentication.

## 1. Chapter / Heading (باب)

بَابُ بَدْءِ الْوَحْيِ

"How the Divine Revelation Started"

Also includes:

- The title given by Imam al-Bukhari
- Qur'anic evidence related to the chapter:

{إِنَّا أَوْحَيْنَا إِلَيْكَ كَمَا أَوْحَيْنَا إِلَى نُوحٍ وَالنَّبِيِّينَ مِنْ بَعْدِهِ}

[Surah al-Nisa: 163]

## 2. Isnad / Chain of Narrators (إسناد)

حَدَّثَنَا الْحُمَيْدِيُّ عَبْدُ اللَّهِ بْنُ الزُّبَيْرِ، قَالَ: حَدَّثَنَا سُفْيَانُ، قَالَ: حَدَّثَنَا يَحْيَى بْنُ سَعِيدٍ الْأَنْصَارِيُّ، قَالَ: أَخْبَرَنِي مُحَمَّدُ بْنُ إِبْرَاهِيمَ التَّيْمِيُّ، أَنَّهُ سَمِعَ عَلْقَمَةَ بْنَ وَقَّاصٍ اللَّيْثِيَّ، يَقُولُ: سَمِعْتُ عُمَرَ بْنَ الْخَطَّابِ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ عَلَى الْمِنْبَرِ قَالَ: سَمِعْتُ رَسُولَ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ يَقُولُ:

Narrator Chain:

- Imam al-Bukhari → Al-Humaydi → Sufyan → Yahya ibn Sa'id al-Ansari → Muhammad ibn Ibrahim al-Taymi → 'Alqamah ibn Waqqas al-Laythi → Umar ibn al-Khattab → Prophet Muhammad ﷺ

## 3. Matn / Text of the Hadith (متن)

«إِنَّمَا الْأَعْمَالُ بِالنِّيَّاتِ، وَإِنَّمَا لِكُلِّ امْرِئٍ مَا نَوَى، فَمَنْ كَانَتْ هِجْرَتُهُ إِلَى دُنْيَا يُصِيبُهَا، أَوْ إِلَى امْرَأَةٍ يَنْكِحُهَا، فَهِجْرَتُهُ إِلَى مَا هَاجَرَ إِلَيْهِ»

Translation:

"Actions are judged by intentions, and every person will get according to what he intended. So whoever migrated for worldly gain or to marry a woman, then his migration is for what he migrated for."

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

1- بَابُ بَدْءِ الْوَحْيِ

قَالَ الشَّيْخُ الْإِمَامُ الْحَافِظُ أَبُو عَبْدِ اللَّهِ مُحَمَّدُ بْنُ إِسْمَاعِيلَ بْنِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ بْنِ الْمُغِيرَةِ الْبُخَارِيُّ رَحِمَهُ اللَّهُ تَعَالَى آمِينَ:  
كَيْفَ كَانَ بَدْءُ الْوَحْيِ إِلَى رَسُولِ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ؟  
وَقَوْلُ اللَّهِ جَلَّ ذِكْرُهُ: {إِنَّا أَوْحَيْنَا إِلَيْكَ كَمَا أَوْحَيْنَا إِلَى نُوحٍ وَالنَّبِيِّينَ مِنْ بَعْدِهِ} [النساء: 163]

حَدَّثَنَا الْحُمَيْدِيُّ عَبْدُ اللَّهِ بْنُ الزُّبَيْرِ، قَالَ: حَدَّثَنَا سُفْيَانُ، قَالَ: حَدَّثَنَا يَحْيَى بْنُ سَعِيدٍ الْأَنْصَارِيُّ، قَالَ: أَخْبَرَنِي مُحَمَّدُ بْنُ إِبْرَاهِيمَ التَّيْمِيُّ، أَنَّهُ سَمِعَ عَلْقَمَةَ بْنَ وَقَّاصٍ اللَّيْثِيَّ، يَقُولُ:  
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«إِنَّمَا الْأَعْمَالُ بِالنِّيَّاتِ، وَإِنَّمَا لِكُلِّ امْرِئٍ مَا نَوَى، فَمَنْ كَانَتْ هِجْرَتُهُ إِلَى دُنْيَا يُصِيبُهَا، أَوْ إِلَى امْرَأَةٍ يَنْكِحُهَا، فَهِجْرَتُهُ إِلَى مَا هَاجَرَ إِلَيْهِ»

# Contribution of Madhhab Imams to Hadith Collection

## Imam Malik

**Hadith Book:** Al-Muwatta

**Based On:** Hadiths of the Prophet ﷺ, Sayings of Sahabah and Tabi'in, Practice of the people of Madinah

**Special Feature:** One of the earliest Hadith collections, Combines Hadith and Fiqh

## Imam Ahmad ibn Hanbal

**Hadith Book:** Musnad Ahmad ibn Hanbal

**Based On:** Hadiths arranged according to Sahabah narrators

**Special Feature:** Contains 30,000+ Hadiths, One of the largest Hadith collections

## Imam al-Shafi'i

**Note:** No independently compiled Hadith collection book by Imam al-Shafi'i himself. Musnad al-Shafi'i was later compiled from his narrations by students and scholars.

**Contribution:** Contributed greatly to Hadith principles and Usul al-Fiqh through Al-Risalah

## Imam Abu Hanifa

**Note:** No independently compiled Hadith collection book by Imam Abu Hanifa himself. Musnad Abu Hanifa was later compiled from his narrations.

**Contribution:** Focused on Verification of narrators, Strong narrations, Application of Hadith in Fiqh

# What Makes a Hadith **Sahih** (Authentic)?

A Hadith is classified as **Sahih** only when it satisfies five rigorous conditions — each designed to ensure the integrity of the narration from source to recorder.



## Continuity of Isnād

Every narrator directly heard from the previous — no gaps in the chain.



## 'Adalah — Integrity

Each narrator must be upright, truthful, and morally trustworthy.



## Ḍabt — Precision

Strong memory or accurate written preservation is required.



## No Contradiction (عدم الشذوذ)

Must not conflict with stronger narrations or the Qur'an.



## No Hidden Defect (عدم العلة)

Must be free from subtle, concealed flaws known as *'Ilal*.

# Weak & Rejected Hadith



## Mawḍū' — Fabricated

Completely false narrations invented and falsely attributed to the Prophet ﷺ. Often identifiable by implausible promises or an absent authentic chain.



## Ḍa'īf — Weak

Fails to meet one or more conditions of Ṣaḥīḥ. Weakness arises from poor memory, a broken chain, or an unknown (majhūl) narrator.

## Why This Matters

Distinguishing fabricated and weak narrations from authentic ones is among the most consequential tasks of Hadith scholarship. Acting on a fabricated Hadith risks attributing falsehood to the Prophet ﷺ — a matter of the utmost gravity.

- Weak narrations may still be cited in *faḍā'il* (virtuous deeds) contexts by some scholars, with conditions
- Fabricated narrations are categorically rejected in all contexts

# Types Based on Chain Breaks

Scholars developed precise terminology for every kind of discontinuity in the isnād — each type reveals where and how the chain fails.

## Mursal (مرسل)

A Tābi'ī narrates directly from the Prophet ﷺ, omitting the Ṣaḥābī entirely.

## Mu'dal (معضل)

Two or more *consecutive* narrators are missing in the chain.

1

2

3

4

## Munqaṭi' (منقطع)

A single narrator is missing anywhere in the chain — not necessarily at the beginning or end.

## Mu'allaq (معلق)

The chain is omitted entirely or partially from the beginning. Example: Imam al-Bukhārī cites a narration without any chain.

# Shādh, Munkar & the Ḥasan Grade

## Contradicting Narrations

### Shādh (شاذ)

A *reliable* narrator contradicts the majority of more reliable narrators. e.g., 10 students report one wording; 1 reliable student reports differently.

### Munkar (منكر)

A *weak* narrator contradicts reliable narrators — similar to Shādh, but the dissenting narrator is not trustworthy.

## The Ḥasan Grade

### Ḥasan li-Dhātihi (حسن لذاته)

Slightly below Ṣaḥīḥ in strength; narrators are acceptable and reliable, but marginally less precise.

### Ḥasan li-Ghayrihi (حسن لغيره)

Originally weak, elevated to Ḥasan by the existence of multiple supporting chains (*shawāhid*).



# 'Ilm al-Rijāl — The Science of Narrators

Alongside Hadith collections, Muslim scholars compiled exhaustive biographical dictionaries of every known narrator — a systematic effort unparalleled in pre-modern historiography.

1

## Early Stage

Biographies of trustworthy and weak narrators compiled together in unified works.

2

## Later Development

Scholars separated narrators into dedicated works: *Thiqāt* (reliable) and *Ḍu'afā'* (weak).

3

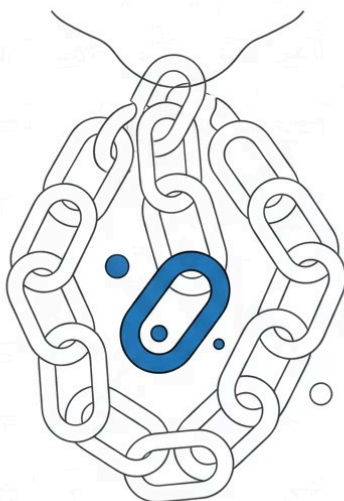
## Mature Discipline

Highly specialised sciences emerged — 'Ilal, death dates, nicknames, and companion biographies.

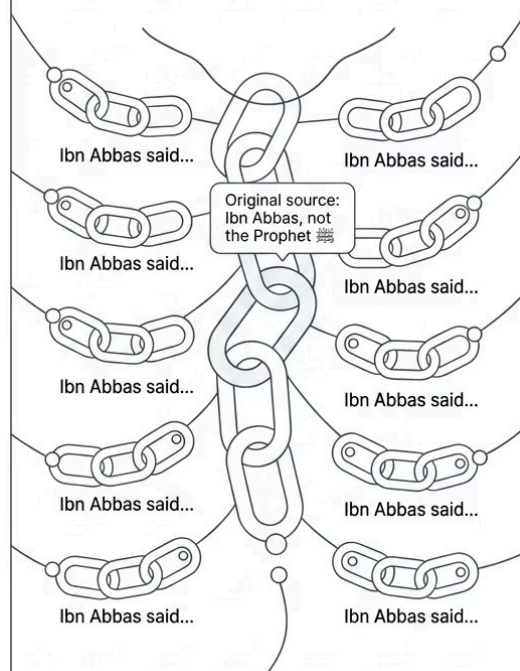


# The Science of 'Ilal — Hidden Defects

**VISIBLE NARRATION:**  
“The Prophet ﷺ said...”



**EXPANDED: 'X-rAY'**  
**Under the rifying glass**



**'X-RAY' UNDER**  
**MAGNIFYING GLASS**

## What Are 'Ilal?

'Ilal (علل) are subtle, concealed defects in a Hadith that are not apparent to the untrained eye — discoverable only through deep comparative analysis of chains and texts.

## Famous Scholars of 'Ilal

- Imām al-Tirmidhī
- Ibn Abī Ḥātim al-Rāzī
- Ibn al-Jawzī
- Imām al-Dāraquṭnī

**i** A narration may *appear* Prophetic, but comparative analysis reveals it is actually a Companion's statement — a classic hidden defect.

# Specialised Categories of Rijāl Literature



## Kutub al-Wafayāt

Books recording the death dates of narrators, enabling scholars to verify whether two narrators could have physically met.



## Asmā' wa al-Kunā

Works listing full names, fathers' names, and *kunyah* (e.g., Abū..., Umm...) to resolve identity confusion among narrators.



## Ma'rifat al-Ṣaḥābah

Biographies of the Companions of the Prophet ﷺ. Key works by Ibn Ḥajar al-'Asqalānī and Ibn 'Abd al-Barr.



## Al-Alqāb (الألقاب)

Books of narrator nicknames and epithets. Examples: *al-A'raj* (the lame), *al-A'mash* (weak eyesight).

# Al-Mawḍū'āt & Ikhtilāṭ

## Collections of Fabricated Hadith

**Al-Mawḍū'āt** are specialised books that catalogue fabricated narrators and fabricated Hadiths. Rather than dismiss them silently, scholars compiled these works to *warn* subsequent generations and protect the Sunnah from corruption.

⊗ Citing from al-Mawḍū'āt lists as if they were authentic is a serious scholarly error — these works serve as **warning references**, not sources.

## Ikhtilāṭ — Memory Confusion

**Ikhtilāṭ** (اختلاط) refers to narrators whose memory became mixed or confused in later life due to illness, old age, or other causes.

### Before Confusion

Narrations **accepted** — memory was intact and reliable.

### After Confusion

Narrations **rejected** — memory no longer trustworthy.



# Key Takeaways

## 1 Five Conditions Define Authenticity

Continuity of isnād, integrity, precision, freedom from contradiction, and absence of hidden defects.

## 2 Terminology Is Precise and Purposeful

Every category — Mursal, Mu'ḍal, Shādh, Ḥasan — pinpoints an exact type of weakness or nuance.

## 3 'Ilm al-Rijāl Is a Science in Its Own Right

The biographical and critical literature surrounding narrators is as sophisticated as the Hadith collections themselves.